
UNIT 17 PUBLIC RELATIONS AND CORPORATE COMMUNICATION

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17.0 INTRODUCTION

This unit introduces the concept of public relations and several definitions of public relations in an attempt to clarify the parameters of the discipline. The distinctions are made between public relations and corporate communication. The evolution of public relations is recounted to give context to the profession. Public relations and corporate communications are comparatively the same, though the objectives and tactics of both are different – even conflicting. Public relations creatively promotes the favorable image of its client to the public, corporate communication adheres to the complicated bylaws of compliance in both internal and external communication, promoting the integrity of a corporation with very little room for creativity. And while they are very different, both types of communication play pivotal role in any company's success.

Public relations is a way for individuals or companies to heighten and strengthen their position. This is the professional task of Public Relations Department or associated firms for the sake of their clients. Public Relations usually implicate communicating with the media or professionals to introduce the clients in the most passive way possible. It also involves coordinated efforts with independent society and organisations to create kindness within the society and propagate the client's image.

Managing the flow of information between individuals or an organization is good public relations. Public relations may include an institutions or organisation or

individual getting benefit of exposure to their society using issues of interest of public and news items that are not advertisement means it does not require direct payment to anyone. The aim of public relations by a company or any one or individual or organisation often is to believe something that is interested to the public, investors, stake holders, partners, employees, to maintain a certain point of view about it, it may be belongs to leadership, products, companies profit or of political type any decisions.

17.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit you will be able to:

- explain the scope and importance of public relations;
- differentiate between public relations and corporate communication;
- describe the nature of duties of public relations officer;
- explain tools and tips of public relations and corporate communications; and
- explain the need for corporate communication.

17.2 DEFINITION OF PUBLIC RELATIONS

Managing the flow of information/ knowledge or data between individual, organisation, society or within the public is the practice of public relations. Public relations may include an organisation, establishment, or individual or any one getting benefit to their society using chapters or issues to related societies interest and news stories that do not require any type of payment or any type of commercial dealing. The aim of public relations by a company or individual or any organisation often is to induce the public, investors, partners, employees, and other stakeholders to maintain a certain viewpoint about it, its leadership, products, any type of decisions, or orders. Basic and routine activities included in this are speaking at conferences or special gathering, winning any type of awards, working with the media persons, and employee (staff) communication. Public relations is a professional and commercial practice dedicated to promoting effective two-way communication between some organisation or entity, such as an industry, organisation, political party or leadership and persons whose opinions can make or break the future success of the supporter.

Public relations has been defined in various ways, the definition often evolving alongside public relations' changing roles and technological advances. The earliest definitions stressed media agency and publicity, while more modern definitions included the concepts of 'involvement' and 'building of good relations' it also called image building.

Ivy Lee and Edward Louis Bernays both are called the Father of Public Relations. They have established the first definition of public relations in the early 1900s as, *"A management function, which tabulates public attitudes, defines the policies, procedures, and interests of an organization... followed by executing a programme of action to earn public understanding and acceptance."* PRSA (Public Relations Society of America) in 2011 initiated a crowdsourcing campaign and public vote that produced the following definition of Public Relation; *"Public relations is a strategic communication process that*

builds mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and their publics.”

In simple way we have to say that, the above definition is focusing on the basic concept of public relations is a communication, conversation or discussions process, this conversation may be one way or two way or in any way. This process may be strategic in nature and stressed on ‘interdependent relationships’, “procedure” is preferable to “any type of management function,” which can evoke ideas of top-down, one-way communications. “Inter association” relates to public relations’ role in helping to bring together organisations, institution or individuals with their key shareholders. “Publics or society” is preferable to “shareholders,” as the former relates to the very “public” nature and work of public relations, whereas “shareholders” has connotations of publicly-traded companies or society based companies.

As a management function, public relations also covers the following:

- Anticipating, reviewing, calculating, expecting and explicating public or society’s opinion, attitudes and issues that might impact, for good or ill, the operations and plans of the organisation.
- Discussions and counselling are an important part of the management at all levels in the organisation or institutions with regard to policy decisions, courses of action and communication, taking into account their public implications and the institution’s social or citizenship responsibilities.
- Research is the most important part of any organisation, with the help of research any institution can change its plans at any time. Conducting research and evaluating the report is an important task of institutions it is continuing task, after the research programmes of action, and communication to achieve the informed public understanding is necessary to the success of any institutions or organisation’s aims. These may include marketing; financial; fund raising; employee, community or government relations, personal level or and other programmes.
- Planning and implementing the objectives are also one of the important parts of organisations or institutions. With the help of planning any one can change public policy. Setting objectives, planning, budgeting, recruiting and training staff and developing facilities are the other aspects to consider.

17.3 PUBLIC RELATIONS AND JOURNALISM

As everyone knows that the role of public relations is to promote image in the eyes of society, everyone related or without related to the client. Public relations is free to make use of any words, stories, news items, photographs, new media in to innovative and interesting newspaper release. As for corporate communication, a profession that prides itself for glorying compliantly within the lines, there is almost no chance to spin any word, stories, photographs or any information related with the media. In such case if we consider public relations and corporate communication as sister professions a person might consider one as younger and another as older. It is important in public relations that the objective is newsworthy for news room, media or press. Here we should know that the newsworthiness depends upon the client.

With corporate communication it may take a complicated approval process as long as your arm to get a short company email out to the press or to its employee-base. And though the two businesses are vastly different, they both serve a very specific and useful purpose when it comes to communicating to the public or society or stakeholders. The specialist of corporate communication and the specialist of public relations are the invaluable advocates of any organisation or institution whose reputation and profitability can often depend upon these persons. The role of both persons can be an exciting and lucrative field to get into since both media marketing and business technology are growing fields of opportunity.

The work of corporate communication specialists is about more than to flourish organisations' story to the society or the people connecting with the organisation. It is often the subject of issue of society, environment, health and satisfaction of the company's staff. The job of corporate communicator is to spread ultra-fine messages to society or company workers. Corporate communication has a responsibility to the industry or its business, to its workers, it means employee, to its shareholders or stake holders and most important part of the any commercial organisation is to its customers - the mission is very responsible.

On the contrary, the public relations has many more responsibilities. The main responsibility is to make headlines for the media and its house journals. These news items and stories play an important role in attracting the attention of the media and the public, stakeholders, and related people -often by any means necessary. This means it is not true that public relations firms are underhanded and lacking integrity. Public relations are directed to the media houses or press. This means newspapers, magazines, radio, television and the internet, social media and new media. Publicity materials reach media through many channels. After briefing the information any organisation generally has very little control over the message or given information or news item or stories that get out into the media. After giving information, news or any item for the media house it is the journalists and reporters or media house, editor or his representative who process the message.

For corporate communications, most of the information, article or messages are directed internally to its employee-base, customers and partners, stakeholders or inter-related persons via email, memos and the occasional press releases or media briefing.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the functions of public relations?

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2. What tools of media can be employed for a company's public relations?

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17.4 THE PUBLIC RELATIONS OFFICER: DUTIES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The spokesperson or media specialist is known as public relations officer. He works for a company or private organisations or institutions. The main role of the public relations officer is to convey the policies and interest stories of any organisation or company to the society or target oriented public through various modes or available best modes to the media.

In almost all sectors the need of public relations officer can be found. This need is not for only organisations but also for private agencies, advertising agencies or companies, government agencies, (Govt. includes State and Central). His main duty is to maintain the reputation of the institution, organisation or any company in the eyes of media or society. The major responsibility of the any public relations officer is to work for the organisation and his duty is to promote the services of establishment where he is working. For the promotion of the establishment he has to organise press conferences, exhibitions, publishing articles, use website and decorate it. At the time of launching new products of the any company the main job of the public relations officer is to arrangement promotion of products, he has to plan for promotional strategies keeping target audience in his mind.

A public relations officer has the ability to interact with lots of people at the same time and that is why he is called an outgoing person. He has to interact with potential clients, media persons, stakeholders and so on. He is responsible to answer the questions of the public and the media persons regarding any issue that arises about products or services of the company. The public relations officer is supposed to be the head of communication because he is supposed to be an expert of the communication, public relations and public affairs in any organisation or institution. His primary duty is to manage communication risk and opportunities of any business institutions. He is responsible for stakeholders, media, shareholders, bloggers, officers, influential members of institutions, society or community, media persons, public, analysts, customers, invertors, company board members and all factors related with the institution. His duty is also not limited to advise the institution. He is responsible for the given suggestions about impact of ongoing reputation of the institution.

A PR officer is not limited to any particular job; it is an ever-expanding area of concern. Apart from all of these, he has to perform the tasks listed here:

1. He has to monitor issues related to the company and give his opinion to the organisation as to certain issues.
2. Advise the management on policy issues and communication strategies regarding new products or any issues related with the company's image.
3. Preparation of budget and planning public relations programmes.
4. On behalf of the company he has to present arguments to others and special interest groups.

5. He is responsible for public and must respond to any inquiries related with the company or organisation.
6. Liaising with the media is the main responsibility of the public relations officer. He is responsible to inquire, arrange, interview with media persons, journalists, editors and make statements or distribute the press release. He is also responsible for organising exhibitions, print brochures, and magazines, house journals and any work related with the image building of the company or organisation.
7. He is supposed to assist in preparing documents of the institution or company such as annual reports, edit and submit them to concerned authorities.
8. Writing speeches regarding the company's work, products, and preparation of advertisements, may be visual or print and make public presentations or in front of the company or institution's body or in front of society.
9. Production of visual (film or video) and audio material, including managing a website, and publishing it on the web.
10. Organisation of special events such as visits of workers, stakeholders, exhibitions, special functions, opening days and anniversary.
11. Media training is an important part and public relations officer has to prepare such type of training to company workers every year for good communication skill.
12. Planning for the future is an important task which is supposed to be done by the PRO.

17.5 TOOLS OF PUBLIC RELATIONS

The things actively prepared and used by PR professionals for the promotion of company or organisation or individuals or for the use of their client and stakeholders. For the powerful presentation or for good communication following are the important tools of public relations.



Fig. 1

17.5.1 News Release

Press release is also called news release. Some people describe it as media release or press statement. The release is in the form of written or recorded communication means the visuals as directed by board members for the purpose of declaring something. It is important that the information given has news value. In the field of public relations, the written news release is the most used tool. So many times, the organisations, institutions, company or any individual send news release to give out information or organising the press conferences. The news release is often included in the media “kit”. The main object is to distribute news and it is supposed to be news worthy. The press release is used for issuing information of a particular matter to the press. The way of communicating the release is by email, written communication or by fax to the concerned editors of newspapers, news magazines, radio stations, TV stations. Now in the corporate world most of the companies are using their web sites, blogs, WhatsApp or new media channels for publishing the news item or information to the target customers or the stakeholders of the company or any organisation.

17.5.2 Media Kit

Usually a media kit is known as press kit. Basically this kit is a set of promotional materials and is distributed to press/media persons before the press briefing or press conference.

Such kits are distributed at the time of announcement of new products or service. Normally, such kits are distributed before the press conference or media briefings. Content of such kits often depend on the purpose of the press meet or press briefing. The content, need of the organiser of the conference, the goal of the client and the target media group are the important factors in preparing the media kit. The main features of the media kit are:

- Importance to be given to individuals, and company’s product.
- Give a brief history or background of the company or organisation.
- Provide information in written or in video or audio format.
- Provide details about the company or your organisation with information of board of managers.
- If necessary, make power point presentations.
- Give report of the company with photographs of officers and products.
- Provide all information related to the press briefing, if possible, on a CD or in pen drive.

17.5.3 Blog

This is a form of new media, usually used by corporates. In a blog on the web site of the company of any organisation or any individual can create and publish information about the company or individual. The use of internet is essential for the blog. Typically, it is run by an individual or any firm or group. This may be written or in video format. It can be in conversational mode also. In the blog the items are posted or displayed with the newest style at the top or on the new page. This is one of the popular means of communication. Since 1995 blogging has been popular. Blogging is a two way communication. It means anyone can comment on the information given by the blogger or the company or the institution. Blogs affect public opinion and it is a new way of communication and it does not have any physical barriers to reach people all over the globe. It has its own limitations.

Blogs are created to focus on the special issue or to promote a special product or transmit news. Blogs combine text, images, videos, audios, music and any other. Because of these functions, blogs are popular amongst users of new media. It is a powerful means of communication. Some of the companies provide blog postings on sites such as myspace.com and blogger.com among others. They allow users free access to create and edit the blogs sitting in any part of the world.

Yahoo team allows a type of blogging in which photos, pictures and files can be uploaded and viewed by visitors. A blog has public relations applications as a communication tool between internal publics or between internal and external publics. Some of the important uses of the blogs are as follows:

- The important feature of the blog is it has a feedback system. Blog is an official web page. It is the head of the company who communicates and takes feedback from the client or employees.
- Blogs can be used for promoting new products, announcing any new information related to people or society.
- Blogs have been effectively used by media persons to interact with the readers and check the responses to stories, news items, photos and editorials.
- It is a useful media tool at the time of crisis management.

On the flip side using the internet can be dangerous for the corporate world because of hacking and threats from parallel organisations. Some of the threats are:

- This is a totally free form of information and communication it is very difficult to judge the response at each level.
- Professionally any one can use, edit, or comment on blogs of the company and comment badly on the blog. Such comments are harmful to the company.
- Blogger has to be attentive at every stage on the blog.
- There is no control over anonymous postings.
- The threat is also from disgruntled employees who can make comments against the administration.
- It can spread rumors quickly and due to this anxiety may increase and create bad impression of the company.
- Information in blogs tends to remain online forever.
- It is easy to manipulate information in the digital world.

17.5.4 Media Relations

In public relations the most important task is to maintain media relations. Media relations means not only connect with the media persons but also includes giving out information about the company's products, or any information which is useful for the promotion of the company or the institution and its services to the press and media industry who publicise the information on the TV, radio, Internet, in newspapers and other publicity agencies. The public relations practitioners connect with the media people on the social matters of the company or organisation.

17.5.5 Publicity

The publicity plan is always adventurous. The news media constitute a major factor in public relations. Proper selection of mass media is essential in preparing and placing news release or news, article or any other publicity material. The material is designed to create attention for client or to publicise larger event. A carefully planned campaign is used for publicity. News, article or any form of information given for publicity needs to be value-based so that it can be published by media persons. The major tools used for the publicity are newspapers, magazines, radio and television, new media, handouts, posters and handouts. The basic types of publicity are news releases, business features, articles, service features, financial and background editorial material. Such material is read-worthy and useful for the media.

17.5.6 Media Tours

Such types of tours are organised by the company or any other organization for to show their success stories. These tours are useful to promote or advertise company's newly launched products. This is one of the effective publicity tools for promoting the product or to achieve the set goals. The spokesperson goes to other important cities to meet media persons for introducing new products. In such meeting he offers goods kit or gift of the products to media persons. Sometimes the public relations officer calls the media persons to visit the company for showing new products or the progress of company through an organised media tour of the company. Most of the time celebrities can also be used for the media tours. At the time of such tour it is the responsibility of the public relations officer to attend the media persons. For the tour, the PRO can call senior journalists, editor or specialists.

17.5.7 Special Events

At the time of launching of the new products or special day such as foundation day of the company, or birth anniversary of any national leader, the company or the business firm organises a special event. In such events, the company may launch new products or show their profit or their social responsibility activities to media persons. This can improve the organisation's reputation in the society. In such events, the arrangement of party, dinner or any other hospitality is offered. This attracts the attention of media persons and it gets good coverage. It is the responsibility of public relations persons to organise such events in a planned manner. These are some of the effective and mostly used public relations tools and methods which are implemented and followed by organisations and individuals.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. List a few qualities of a public relations person.

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2. What are the tools of public relations?

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17.6 GOVERNMENT PUBLIC RELATIONS

As discussed earlier, public relations is the practice of managing the information between an individual and an organisation or government agencies. Government is a non-profit entity, which works for the society. Public relations involves communication between various organizations and the public. This is useful for building public opinion, educate people and convey particular message to society.

The government public relations contributes to:

1. Effective implementation of public policy towards society
2. Assisting in all types of media in coverage of government activities.
3. Reporting and providing information to the citizenry on its activities.
4. Increasing the internal cohesion of the agency.
5. Increasing the sensitivity of its publics or society.

National objectives of public relations for government: To educate, inform and instruct the society is the basic function of government public relations department. The indirect or direct motivation should be to discharge these functions in a purposeful manner. The main object of national public relations is nonpolitical, non-controversial and in national interest. The objectives should further the interests and the well-being of the public as a whole and promote the many-sided development of the country. The objectives should be long term ones and need not necessarily change with political vagaries.

17.7 CORPORATE COMMUNICATION - DEFINITION

Any communication activity undertaken within or by an organisation to create a favorable perspective by its stakeholders is called corporate communication. It usually comprises of various messages created and issued to its employees, media and channel partners and general public.

Some of the key responsibility areas of the corporate communication department or personnel are:

- 1) To create a brand identity
- 2) To promote the brand and company
- 3) To devise a communication strategy within and outside the company
- 4) To put the strategy into action within and outside the company

To simplify further, corporate communication includes media relations, corporate advertising and employee communication as well. The communication could be aimed at handling an internal crisis, making a new employee feel welcome, creating safety booklets or films for workers of a factory facility or even communicating with various vendors and retailers for better business relationships.

Corporate communication can be further divided in three segments:

- 1) **Management communication:** It is the communication by the managers. The various components include planning, organising, leading and getting reports. Any communication done for these purposes can be categorised as management communication.
- 2) **Marketing communication:** Any sort of communication that aims to market the brand, the company or the products to the stakeholders is known as marketing communication.
- 3) **Institutional communication:** Any communication done to strengthen the institute, relationship between management and employees is known as institutional communication.

Following are the key feature areas related to corporate communications:

17.7.1 Corporate Branding

This is the process of creating a perception of the company that could be producing a number of products or services. The perception is usually defined by a name or symbols and ideas. For e.g. Reliance as a brand name has a unique identity from, let us say, Tatas and it has further different branches such as Reliance Digital, Reliance Fresh and Reliance Jio.

17.7.2 Corporate Identity

Three types of identities that can be distinguished are:

Perceived identity: One that is assumed to be by its members and other stakeholders.

Projected identity: One that is manifest through various communication practices of the company.

Desired identity: One that is aimed for by the management and the communication department.

17.7.3 Corporate Responsibility

There are few practices that help the organisations work for the society and win trust of their stakeholders. It also creates a respect for the company in the market. For e.g. you must have seen ads telling you that when you buy this particular product some amount is donated to charity.

17.7.4 Corporate Reputation

Reputation basically means an assessment of organisation by the stakeholders. It is built over ages with philanthropy, quality assurance and adopting best practices in the industry.

17.7.5 Crisis Communication

It is considered to be a sub-specialty of corporate communication. It deals not only with how in-house catastrophes are dealt with by the company but also how various situations of concerns are avoided and handled externally as well.

17.7.6 In-house Communication

For the functioning of any organisation, good communication practices are required within units and departments. In-house communication happens in two ways:

Vertical communication: It takes place when communication happens between departments or people with hierarchy. Superiors send information to the subordinates through oral or written means. Oral methods would include face to face conversation, telephonic conversation, speeches and meetings while the written forms would include mails, displays, manuals and handbooks. Subordinates would also use these methods to convey their opinions, report and raise concerns.

Horizontal communication: When communication happens between departments or unit of same hierarchy is called horizontal communication. Let us look at a few definitions: **Ricky W. Griffin** has written that, “Horizontal communication involves colleagues and peers at the same level of the organization. “On the other hand, **Bartol and Martin** opine: “Horizontal communication is lateral or diagonal message exchange either within work – unit boundaries, involving peers who report to the same supervisor or across-work unit boundaries, involving individuals who report to different supervisors.”

While the major purpose of vertical communication is to delegate tasks and report, the horizontal communication serves the purpose of coordination between departments.

17.7.7 Investor and Vendor Communication

Strategies used to keep various vendors, partners and investors involved are categorised under this. It may include organising special events and sending seasonal and festival greetings as well.

17.8 CORPORATE COMMUNICATION: TOOLS AND METHODS

Various tools may be employed to communicate within the corporate structures: meetings, emails, presentations, films, events and messages may be utilised as per the need and the gravity of the message.

Here are a few tips for effective corporate communication:

- 1) Keep the corporate brand and its intent in mind while framing the communication.
- 2) Think of a favorable tool. Sometime a meeting would waste time where a mail could have sufficed.

- 3) Frame your message according to the target audience.
- 4) Keep all the people in loop who are even peripherally related to the issue.
- 5) Keep a difference between personal and professional.
- 6) Document every step of the communication process.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the two types of in-house communication process?

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17.9 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we learnt about the practice and the need for building public relations by an organisation. We discussed various methods, tools and techniques about establishing favorable public relations. Elaborating on media relations and journalism in the time of public relations, this unit also stressed on the need of creating media kits and other ways of getting the media involved.

We also touched upon the need and importance of corporate communication. Covering various areas and aspects a corporate organisation would need through its communication processes, we also talked about vertical and horizontal communication patterns within an organisation. Lastly we learnt about the need and the process of maintaining good communication within and outside the corporate structures.

17.10 KEYWORDS

- Angle** : Particular emphasis of a story or broadcast; also called “slant”.
- Campaign** : Organised efforts to plan, formulate, or alter the opinion of any group or groups on a selected subject.
- Coverage** : Extent of distribution of publicity or opinion-affecting material.
- Debrief** : Originally, to interrogate a serviceman after return from combat area. Now includes interviewing members of an organization or their readings of public attitudes.

17.11 FURTHER READINGS

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- Select a company with which you are familiar. Describe the company's corporate communication in terms of its corporate identity, image and reputation.
- Write a press release for the launch of Honda's first diesel car 'Amaze'. Refer to course material on how to write a press release and also prepare a power point presentation.
- Develop a PR programme for an organisation of your choice (organisation may be of government owned or public welfare) it should cover development of public relations objective, communication programme, content / message development, media co-ordination and impact / result monitoring.

17.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Various functions of public relations are:
 - Measuring public opinion that might impact the operations and plans of the organisation.
 - Discussions and counseling of all parties involved aligned to the institution's social or citizenship responsibilities.
 - Conducting the research and evaluating the marketing; financial; fund raising; employee, community or government relations, personal level or/ and other programmes.
 - Planning and implementing the objectives.
2. Following are various tools of media which can be utilised for public relations: newspapers, magazines, radio, television and the internet, social media and new media.

Check Your Progress 2

1. A good public relations officer must be a loyal and dedicated worker who understands the brand and its responsibilities. He/ she must be good with communications skills and should be able to draft messages in accordance with the company's image.
2. Following are the few of the tools for public relations: News releases, media kits, blogs, media relations, publicity, media tours and special events.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Corporate communication happens in two ways:
 - a) Vertical communication: When communication happens between departments or people with hierarchy.
 - b) Horizontal communication: When communication happens between departments or units of same hierarchy.

